Dear Girl

By Aija Mayrock

Dear Girl,

open your eyes.

We have come so far it's easy to resign.

We've got "equality"

but public policy shows the contrary, honestly.

One in six women could be raped in their lives

and it's mostly seen as a victimless crime.

What should every girl know?

You are not some puppet in a puppet show.

Expose the double standards,

the hypocrisy, the hate.

It is never too late.

This is the moment of girls taking the reins.

It is Time's Up.

It is Me Too.

It is everyone from me

to you

who has spoken

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or stayed silent

but strong.

And for every survivor who speaks

only to be met

with intimidation, investigation, and disbelief:

Dear Girl,

you will be believed.

If not by Senate floors and investigators,

we will hear you, Dear Girl,

we will see you, Dear Girl,

we will stand by you.

For the survivor three thousand miles away or the one next door,

you are heard.

Justice will not always prevail

but we will continue to fight

tooth and nail.

You are heard.

So that our sisters and daughters will never be asked,

rather

harassed,

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whether they wanted it,

regretted it,

or just forgot.

Believe me,

no one forgot.

INTRODUCTION

Against all evidence, American men have come to believe that the world --economically, socially, politically—is tilted against them. Sure, 88% of Fortune 500 CEOs are men, and so are 72% of Congressmen**. Men still earn significantly more money than women for the same work, and men have an unbeaten 45 and 0 record of winning the American Presidency. Even so, findings from the August 2022 American Perspective Survey show that nearly 45% of men ages 18-29 believe they are facing gender-based discrimination.****

When you've been on top for a few thousand years, even small moves toward diversity, equality and inclusion can feel like discrimination.

So today, I speak to women – women who have persevered even after Roe v Wade was overturned by a Supreme Court that was 66% male. In the words of the great Ruth Bader Ginsburg: It's a woman's right to control her own destiny. To be able to make choices without the big brother state felling her what she can and cannot do."

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Dear Everyone,

grab ahold of your voice.

It is time to make a choice

to believe survivors

to pay us all the same

to give women of color equal access and opportunity

to protect the safety of trans girls every day.

Make the choice to change the climate,

make the choice not to stay silent.

This is not the era of girls,

this is the future of girls.

Dear Mother,

I see your fears baked into how you raised me.

I see them tremble from your lips as you warn me.

I know you are terrified of the world that could swallow me whole.

But Mother, you need not fear,

because even if I am swallowed up,

I will kick until I am spit back out.

I will fight with the fists you gave me.

I will shout from the gut you built for me.

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Dear Mother,
you need not worry.
For I am the warrior you always dreamed you'd have.
I will not go down fighting
because I will not go down at all.
When a girl is born into a world
where she has no control over her body,
she learns to live in a body that is not hers, but owned by the state.
She grows up to believe that obedience is her middle name.
When a girl is born into a world
that does not value her body,
she learns to exist on the periphery of society
as if growing into her spine is too much to ask for.
Your cruelty is no match for my spirit.
Try to break me
and you will see
love that pours like blood from my wounds.
To break me, you would have to make me hate,
and like I said,
your cruelty is no match for my spirit.
You tell your daughter that she is being emotional, irrational,
yet you tell your son that he is being strong, smart;
you are teaching your daughter to doubt her feelings,
to question her beliefs.
And so when she is mistreated,
she will think back to what was said
under your roof
and believe those gut feelings we speak of
are merely irrational thoughts,
while your son believes every thought he has is fair and right.
Be careful how you raise your daughters.
Be careful how you raise your sons.
When you teach your daughter
that her body is only pure untouched,
you are teaching her
that she can be ruined at the hand of man.
Raise your daughters like you raise your sons;
the inequality did not begin with her birth,
the inequality begins when you choose to raise your daughter in a box labeled "ladylike"
and your son, in no box, with no label.

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She has a fire that you can see when you look into her eyes,
flames swallow up her self-doubt.
She always runs toward the storm;
nothing scares her more than turning down a challenge,
nothing scares her more than taping down her wicked
tongue.
I am the woman I am today
because my father never clipped my wings,
even in disagreement.
I hear his voice,
all pride and no shame, say --
"And, yes, that is my daughter."
And so I soar.
I soar.
I soar.

Dear Girl,
I wish I could hold you and say
the world will protect you.
But I know it will not,
and in some way,
you, too, know it will not.

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Maybe that's why when people tell you,
"You're too young to understand,"
you smirk with that twinkle in your eye.

White women,
show up
for your sisters of color.

Straight women,
show up
for your lgbtq+ sisters.

Women,
show up,
have the guts
to overlook differences,
because really
the difference is
as drastic as
progress
or
no progress.
We can't afford to divide each other.
Since early days

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we are taught
to compare and compete
with one another.
You are not devalued
even if
the woman next to you
appears to be perfect.
You are not devalued
if your sisters
are achieving
greatness.
You are always of value
if you
value
you.

Dear Sisters,
Show up for those
you might not know
or understand.
Show up for those
you might not

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like at all.
Show up for all of us.

Dear Girl,
You were not born to please,
you were brought here to
disrupt, awaken, and speak truth,
to ease the pain scattered around
and so when you are told to quiet down,
I hope you grow louder.
You might believe the words you speak are weak,
but the echoes of words
can start revolutions.
No good revolution came from
safety and security;
revolution begins when you leap into the unknown
and shout from the rooftops:
I am here. Alone or surrounded by thousands. I am here.
And I am not going anywhere.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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MN State Qualifier

Source information for introductory stats

** https://fortune.com/2025/01/08/the-fortune-500-has-two-new-female-ceos-finally-pushing-that-milestone-above-11/*

*** https://www.pewresearch.org/short-reads/2025/03/03/the-changing-face-of-congress-in-7-charts/*

**** https://www.americansurveycenter.org/newsletter/why-young-men-are-turning-against-feminism/*

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